

Photographs by BK RAMESH



Agenda for Action

Measures proposed by the Yeddyurappa Government in the name of Hindutva

- Bill to ban cow slaughter
- Anti-conversion law aimed to curb religious conversions made by force, fraud or allurements
- Rs 100 crore for Hindu mutts to further the cause of a Hindu rashtra
- Moral education and special yoga classes for students in all state government colleges
- Promoting Akshaya Patra mid-day meal by Iskcon Krishna temple in Bangalore
- Sanskrit and Vedic university in the state capital.

YEDDYURAPPA (SECOND FROM LEFT) WANTS TO REVIVE HINDUTVA; MINORITIES PROTEST THE FIRING IN MYSORE

religious conversions made by "force", "fraud" or "allurement", Christian leaders point out, has been misused to arrest them on fabricated charges.

The Congress' Shivakumar has also hit out at the state Government's promotion of a mid-day meal scheme promoted by leaders of the Iskcon Krishna temple in Bangalore. "Dalit women who were cooking meals in remote villages will lose their jobs because of the government's decision to promote this group. The BJP Government must immediately stop funding the private initiative of the mid-day meal project," he says.

After cows, freedom of religion and mid-day meals, the state Government now wants students in government degree colleges to undergo special moral education and yoga classes coordinated by spiritual leader Sri Sri Ravi Shankar's Art of Living Foundation in Bangalore. Higher education minister Aravind Limbavali chaired an inter-university board meeting in Belgaum on June 30 that resolved to rope in programmes from the Art of Living Foundation. The Government is also planning to set up a Sanskrit and Veda university in Bangalore, which is being questioned by leaders like Karnataka Development Forum President Patil Putappa. He says that the number of faculty teaching Sanskrit at seven universities in the state could be more than students who have enrolled for the courses. And there are enough acharyas who can be teaching the Vedas to students. He wants the Government to instead focus on Kannada and fill all the vacancies for Kannada language teachers and lecturers throughout the state.

These matters are likely to come to a head in the coming Assembly session. "We will make sure the Government does not convert this state into a laboratory for Hindutva," warns Siddharamaiah, the opposition leader in the Assembly. That may just not be enough to stop the BJP, currently in a state of terminal decline, from flexing its muscles. ■



Bhardwaj's announcement.

Attacks on Christians on the Mangalore coast—and on the city pubs by groups affiliated to the Hindutva cause—had already created a headache for the BJP Government. The presence of prominent Hindutva mutts, Pejavar and Adamar, in the Mangalore region has heightened the belief of Hindu groups firming their grip on the party. While Hindu groups allege that Karnataka has become a haven for Christian groups for large-

scale forced religious conversions, a section of the RSS-schooled BJP leadership believes that "Hindu innocents are getting converted to other religions", necessitating the need for an anti-conversion law.

Bangalore Archbishop Bernard Moras says the bill will violate the fundamental right of freedom of conscience and freedom to profess, practise and propagate religion under Article 25 of the Constitution. The bill, which was supposed to curb reli-